States: an observant (though not Orthodox) Jew, Rivlin once said he was "stunned" after attending his first Reform service in New Jersey, which he described with a Hebrew phrase often translated as "idol worship."[7]

The president is selected by the Knesset, not the Israeli public, so it has historically been a vote between two candidates backed by the major left- and right-wing parties. Rivlin, a longtime Knesset speaker who enjoyed warm relations with many of his colleagues, was a logical choice for Likud. But he had one prominent enemy: Netanyahu. The prime minister has harbored a grudge against him for years, partly because Rivlin blocked bills introduced by right-wing lawmakers that he viewed as anti-democratic or racist. (Rivlin also occasionally made jokes about Netanyahu's wife, Sara, a controversial figure who plays a major behind-the-scenes role in her husband's administration.) In a bid to block Rivlin's candidacy, Netanyahu first tried the nuclear option. He proposed eliminating the presidency altogether. When that failed, he pushed Holocaust survivor and Nobel laureate Elie Wiesel as an alternative to Rivlin. That effort failed too. Wiesel refused the job. He wasn't eligible anyway: he wasn't an Israeli citizen. Rivlin eventually got the nomination.

Labor threw its backing behind one of its own long-serving parliamentarians, Binyamin Ben-Eliezer, a thirty-year veteran of the Knesset (and longtime friend of Hosni Mubarak). But Ben-Eliezer, popularly known as "Fouad", was indicted on corruption charges days before the vote and quickly withdrew. His replacement, Meir Sheetrit, had enjoyed a long but unremarkable career in the Knesset, which opened a space for three other candidates to join the race, including a former high court justice and a chemistry professor. Rivlin defeated Sheetrit on the second ballot with 54 per cent of the vote.

After he won, the *New York Times* dryly observed, "Rivlin's politics are far from mainstream."[8] So it would prove—sometimes in surprising ways.

A man of contradictions

Like his predecessor, Rivlin is a career politician. He was elected to the Knesset in 1988, and it would be his home for the next twenty-five years, save for a short period in the 1990s. But the similarities do not go much further. Peres craved the spotlight, the visits to foreign capitals, the celebrity friends he accumulated over the years. Rivlin, with his bulbous nose and